Association for Project Management

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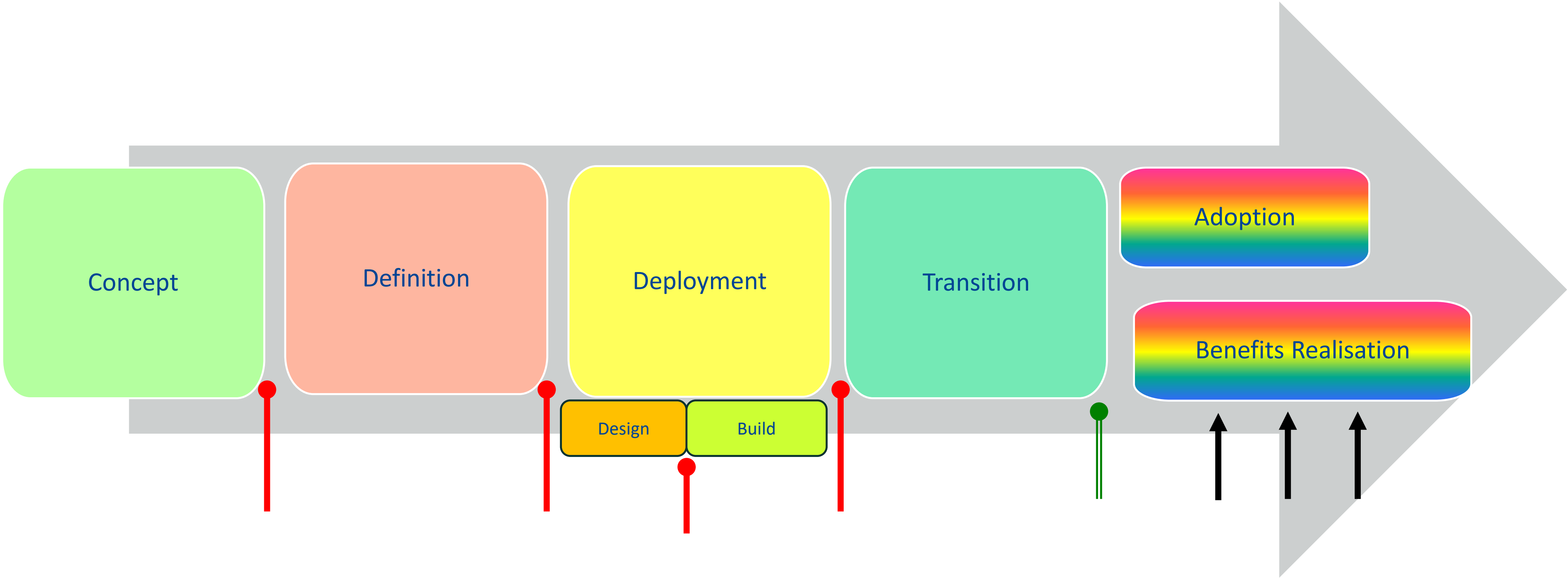
Reviews

Learning objective:

6. Understand reviews as a way of gathering information to provide an assessment on the status of a project and the ongoing viability of the work.

6a) Understand the benefits of conducting reviews throughout the life cycle (including decision gates, benefits reviews and audits).

Reviews



Key:

Decision Gates

Post-project review

Audits - throughout

Benefit realisation review

Types of review

Decision gates

- If the life cycle is linear, these will be event driven. If iterative, these will be time-bound. They lead to increased senior stakeholder involvement.
- Held at the end of each stage or iteration primarily to gain agreement from the sponsor and wider governance board or changes to be incorporated.
- Check that the project is still on track to deliver the benefits as defined in the business case.

Benefits reviews

- Held during benefits realisation, typically 6–12 months after handover.
- Check that the project achieved the business benefits identified within the business case.
- Actions or improvements needed to support the realisation of the benefits can be determined.
- Typically undertaken by the project sponsor.

Audits

- Provide independent compliance assessment and increase stakeholder confidence.
- Held to check that the project is following the agreed governance and processes as defined within quality management plans.
- Conducted by personnel independent of the project.

6b) Know the factors which would typically be reported on to help ensure successful project outcomes.

Factors to be reported on

Progress against the schedule	• Understanding how the project's tasks are progressing against the schedule will help the project manager to assess progress on the overall project and to identify where controlling actions might be required if progress isn't as planned.
Actual spend against planned spend	• Understanding how the project is performing against a set spend curve and any corrective action needed where overspend is identified.
Earned value	• Tracking project spend and understanding the value of the work achieved.
Audit findings and number of non-conformances	• Understanding whether processes being followed are correct and generating the required outputs or alternatively considering any recovery actions needed.
Risks and issues	• Understanding and communicating transparently the risks and issues facing the project and how these need to be monitored and managed.

6c) Understand the importance of producing information and collecting data to inform decision making and communicate actions and decisions to stakeholders.

Importance of information and data

Status reporting	Estimating the project	Risk identification	Problem solving and option appraisals	Information Management	Knowledge management
• So that the project manager can better understand the status of the project in relation to cost, schedule and quality against the acceptance criteria in the project management plan.	• So that more realistic schedules and costs can be developed using past project data.	• So that the need for any subsequent corrective actions to be undertaken or the need for escalation can be determined.	• So that options and solutions to solve project problems and issues can be generated using past project experience.	• To inform the decision-making process at key points, such as gate reviews, by ensuring the relevant information is available in an appropriate format.	• To provide an understanding of when best to schedule quality assurance and quality control activities for the project. • By assessing what was done on past projects and by understanding the optimum times within a project life cycle, activities can be scheduled.

6d) Understand why activities may be re-planned after a review.

Re-planning after a review

Progress monitoring leads to the production of meaningful reports. Such reports allow the assessment of whether any re-planning of activities is needed in the following areas:

- Where achievement of planned scope is not to the required quality.
- Where motivation and satisfaction of team members is low.
- Where performance of contractors and the health of the relationships in the supply chain is poor.
- Where committed costs and cash flow are above original forecasts.
- Where changes to the risk profile and impact on time buffers or cost contingency are needed because of newly identified or changed risks.
- Where effectiveness of communication with stakeholders is lacking.

Photo credit: Markus Winkler